

1.3 Unit 1, Option A: England in the Middle Ages and the Transition to the Early Modern World

Focus

This option concentrates on the theme of power and authority within England over the period covered, with further emphasis on broad developments which can be seen to have promoted the transition to the early modern world. Whichever combinations are chosen, this option enables students to understand both the exercise of power by rulers and the ways in which, and extent to which, that power was liable to challenge.

Clarification of content for each topic can be found in *Appendix 1*.

Students entered for Option A are required to study TWO of the topics from A1-A7.

A1 Alfred the Great and the Vikings, 793-c900

- Anglo-Saxon society in the 9th century: the different kingdoms, Christianity, agriculture and commerce.
- The fury of the Vikings: raids and conquest, 793–870.
- The assault on Wessex and its defence, 870–78.
- Rebuilding and strengthening the West Saxon kingdom, 878–99.

A2 The Norman Conquest and its Impact on England, 1066-1135

- The England of Edward and Harold: economy, society and government.
- William of Normandy and the conquest of 1066.
- Establishing control: rebellions, reprisals, castles and the Domesday survey.
- Anglo-Norman society: a new elite, new customs, a reformed Church.

A3 The Angevin Empire, 1154-1216

- Henry II: position and personality — the creation and expansion of the Angevin Empire.
- Henry and the governance of England: the development of the legal system; Thomas à Becket and the Church.
- Richard I: relations with his father; the Third Crusade; conflict and death in France.
- King John and the loss of the Angevin Empire: conflict with Philip Augustus; rebellion and discontent in England; the Magna Carta.

A4 From Black Death to Great Revolt: England, 1348-81

- Social and economic conditions in mid-14th century England: agriculture population pressures; urbanisation and climate change.
- The origins, nature and course of the Black Death, 1347–50.
- The economic effects of extensive mortality.
- The social and political effects of population loss: the Peasants' Revolt of 1381.

A5 Anglo-French Rivalry: Henry V and Henry VI, 1413-53

- Reasons for the renewal of conflict: the domestic situations in France and England.
- The years of victory: Agincourt to the Treaty of Troyes, 1415–20.
- An infant English king and a French saint or witch: turning the tide of English conquest, 1422–35.